

Oracle access to the model: We can query the model for any state-action pair.



* If we have a data set of N sample transitions (state, action, next state)
 $\{(s_i, a_i, s'_i)\}_{i=1}^N$ where $s'_i \sim P(\cdot | s_i, a_i) \quad \forall i \in \{1, 2, \dots, N\}$,

we can form an estimate transition function $\hat{P}$.

Estimating the transition function: We can sample n transitions for each state-action pair and then compute $\hat{P}$.

1) Data collection: For all $s \in \mathcal{S}$ and $a \in \mathcal{A}$, sample $s' \sim P(\cdot | s, a)$
 n times $\longrightarrow N = |\mathcal{S}| |\mathcal{A}| n$ samples

2) Model estimation: For all $s \in \mathcal{S}$ and $a \in \mathcal{A}$, compute

$$\hat{P}(s' | s, a) = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^N \mathbb{1}[s_i = s, a_i = a, s'_i = s']}{\underbrace{\sum_{i=1}^N \mathbb{1}[s_i = s, a_i = a]}_n}$$

For each $s \in \mathcal{S}, a \in \mathcal{A}$:

$$P(\cdot | s, a) \longrightarrow \begin{bmatrix} p_1 \\ p_2 \\ \vdots \\ p_{|\mathcal{S}|} \end{bmatrix}$$

$$\forall j: p_j \geq 0 \quad \sum_{j=1}^{|\mathcal{S}|} p_j = 1$$

Example:

Data set (state s , action a , next state s')

Consider $s = 2, a = 1$



n samples
for $s=2, a=1$

$\vdots$	$\vdots$	$\vdots$
2	1	2
2	1	4
2	1	4
$\vdots$	$\vdots$	$\vdots$
2	1	7
$\vdots$	$\vdots$	$\vdots$

$$\begin{cases} P(s'=1 | s=2, a=1) = \frac{\#(2, 1, 1)}{n} \\ \vdots \\ P(s'=4 | s=2, a=1) = \frac{\#(2, 1, 4)}{n} \\ \vdots \\ P(s'=|S| | s=2, a=1) = \frac{\#(2, 1, |S|)}{n} \end{cases}$$

Estimation error for the transition function: With finite samples

of transitions (s, a, s') , one cannot learn the transition function perfectly in general.

Question: How can we bound the estimation error of the transition function with finite samples?

Using concentration inequalities

Bounded Difference Property: A function $f: X_1 \times X_2 \times \dots \times X_n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ satisfies the bounded difference property if changing any one of its arguments results in a bounded change in its output. Formally, there should exist constants $c_1, c_2, \dots, c_n$ such that for all $i \in \{1, 2, \dots, n\}$ and for all $x_1 \in X_1, x_2 \in X_2, \dots, x_n \in X_n, x'_i \in X_i$,

$$\max_{\substack{x_1, x_2, \dots, x_n \\ x'_i}} |f(x_1, x_2, \dots, x_{i-1}, x_i, x_{i+1}, \dots, x_n) - f(x_1, x_2, \dots, x_{i-1}, x'_i, x_{i+1}, \dots, x_n)| \leq c_i.$$

McDiarmid's Inequality: Consider independent random variables

$X_1 \in X_1, X_2 \in X_2, \dots, X_n \in X_n$. Let $f: X_1 \times X_2 \times \dots \times X_n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$

be a function satisfying the bounded difference property with bounds

$c_1, c_2, \dots, c_n$, corresponding to the n arguments of f .

For any $\epsilon > 0$, the following holds:

$$\mathbb{P} \left[|f(X_1, X_2, \dots, X_n) - \mathbb{E}[f(X_1, X_2, \dots, X_n)]| \geq \epsilon \right] \leq 2 \exp \left(\frac{-2\epsilon^2}{\sum_{i=1}^n c_i^2} \right).$$

Lemma [Estimation of Categorical Distribution]: Let X be a discrete random variable over $\mathcal{X} = \{1, 2, \dots, d\}$ with categorical distribution

$$\vec{q} = \begin{bmatrix} q_1 \\ q_2 \\ \vdots \\ q_d \end{bmatrix} \text{ where } q_i \geq 0 \quad \forall i \in \{1, 2, \dots, d\} \text{ and } \sum_{j=1}^d q_j = 1.$$

Assume we have n i.i.d. samples $x_1, x_2, \dots, x_n$ of X and form an empirical estimate of $\vec{q}$ as $\hat{\vec{q}} = \begin{bmatrix} \hat{q}_1 \\ \hat{q}_2 \\ \vdots \\ \hat{q}_d \end{bmatrix}$, where $\hat{q}_j = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^n \mathbb{1}[x_i = j]}{n}$.

Then, for any $\epsilon > 0$, it holds that

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}(\text{error} \geq \epsilon') &\leq \delta && \text{low error with} \\ \mathbb{P}(\text{error} < \epsilon') &\geq 1 - \delta && \text{high probability} \end{aligned}$$

$$\mathbb{P}(\|\hat{\vec{q}} - \vec{q}\|_2 \geq \frac{1}{\sqrt{n}} + \epsilon) \leq e^{-n\epsilon^2}.$$

Proof: Let $\tilde{e}_i$ be a random variable (vector) defined based on x_i as

$$\tilde{e}_i = e_j \text{ if } x_i = j, \text{ where } e_j = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \\ \vdots \\ 1 \\ \vdots \\ 0 \end{bmatrix}_{d \times 1} \rightarrow j^{\text{th}} \text{ entry}.$$

$$\text{Then, } \hat{\vec{q}} = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^n \tilde{e}_i}{n}.$$

$$\text{Consider } \vec{\tilde{q}}' = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^n \tilde{e}_i'}{n}, \text{ where } \tilde{e}_i' = \tilde{e}_i \text{ for all } i \in \{1, 2, \dots, n\}$$

except one.

$$f(x_1, x_2, \dots, x_n) = \|\hat{\vec{q}} - \vec{q}\|_2$$

$\downarrow \quad \downarrow \quad \downarrow$
 $\tilde{e}_1 \quad \tilde{e}_2 \quad \tilde{e}_n$

Then, we have

at most two entries of $\vec{\hat{q}}$ & $\vec{\hat{q}}'$ are different by $\frac{1}{n}$

$$\underbrace{\|\vec{\hat{q}} - \vec{q}\|_2}_{f(\vec{e}_1, \vec{e}_2, \dots, \vec{e}_n)} - \underbrace{\|\vec{\hat{q}}' - \vec{q}\|_2}_{f(\vec{e}_1, \dots, \vec{e}_{i-1}, \vec{e}_i, \vec{e}_{i+1}, \dots, \vec{e}_n)} \leq \underbrace{\|\vec{\hat{q}} - \vec{\hat{q}}'\|_2}_{\leq \sqrt{(\frac{1}{n})^2 + (\frac{1}{n})^2}} \leq \frac{\sqrt{2}}{n} \cdot c_i$$

triangle inequality

Therefore, applying McDiarmid's inequality yields

$f(\vec{e}_1, \vec{e}_2, \dots, \vec{e}_n) = \|\vec{\hat{q}} - \vec{q}\|_2$

$$\mathbb{P} \left(\underbrace{\|\vec{\hat{q}} - \vec{q}\|_2}_{f(\cdot)} - \underbrace{\mathbb{E}[\|\vec{\hat{q}} - \vec{q}\|_2]}_{\mathbb{E}[f(\cdot)]} \geq \epsilon \right) \leq \exp \left(\frac{-2\epsilon^2}{\sum_{i=1}^n c_i^2} \right)$$

one-sided version

$$= \exp \left(\frac{-2\epsilon^2}{n \times \frac{2}{n^2}} \right) = e^{-n\epsilon^2}$$

Now, we need to evaluate $\mathbb{E}[\|\vec{\hat{q}} - \vec{q}\|_2]$.

$$\mathbb{E}[\|\vec{\hat{q}} - \vec{q}\|_2] = \mathbb{E} \left[\left\| \frac{\sum_{i=1}^n \tilde{e}_i}{n} - \vec{q} \right\|_2 \right]$$

definition of $\vec{\hat{q}}$

$$\tilde{g}(g(x)) = x \leftarrow \mathbb{E} \left[\sqrt{\left\| \frac{\sum_{i=1}^n \tilde{e}_i}{n} - \vec{q} \right\|_2^2} \right]$$

$$\text{Jensen's inequality} \leftarrow \leq \sqrt{\mathbb{E} \left[\left\| \frac{\sum_{i=1}^n \tilde{e}_i}{n} - \vec{q} \right\|_2^2 \right]} = \frac{1}{n^2} \mathbb{E} \left[\left\| \sum_{i=1}^n \tilde{e}_i - n\vec{q} \right\|_2^2 \right]$$

$$= \frac{1}{n^2} \mathbb{E} \left[\left\| \sum_{i=1}^n (\tilde{e}_i - \vec{q}) \right\|_2^2 \right]$$

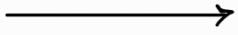
$$\text{triangle inequality + linearity of expectation} \leftarrow \leq \sqrt{\frac{1}{n^2} \sum_{i=1}^n \mathbb{E} \left[\underbrace{\|\tilde{e}_i - \vec{q}\|_2^2}_{(\tilde{e}_i - \vec{q})^T (\tilde{e}_i - \vec{q})} \right]}$$

$$\text{definition of L2 norm} \leftarrow = \sqrt{\frac{1}{n^2} \sum_{i=1}^n \mathbb{E} \left[\tilde{e}_i^T \tilde{e}_i - 2\tilde{e}_i^T \vec{q} + \vec{q}^T \vec{q} \right]}$$

$$\text{linearity of expectation} \leftarrow = \sqrt{\frac{1}{n^2} \sum_{i=1}^n \left(\underbrace{\mathbb{E}[\tilde{e}_i^T \tilde{e}_i]}_1 - 2 \underbrace{\mathbb{E}[\tilde{e}_i^T \vec{q}]}_{\mathbb{E}[\tilde{e}_i^T] \vec{q} = \vec{q}^T \vec{q} = \|\vec{q}\|_2^2} + \underbrace{\mathbb{E}[\|\vec{q}\|_2^2]}_{\|\vec{q}\|_2^2} \right)}$$

$$(\tilde{e}_i)_{i=1}^n \text{ are i.i.d.} \leftarrow = \sqrt{\frac{1}{n^2} n (1 - \|\vec{q}\|_2^2)}$$

$$= \sqrt{\frac{1}{n} (1 - \|\vec{q}\|_2^2)} \leq \frac{1}{\sqrt{n}}$$

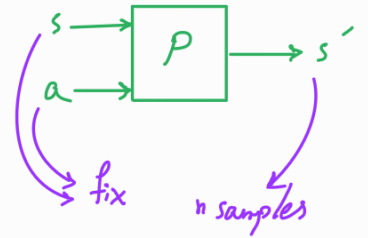


Finally, we obtain the desired result :

$$\mathbb{P} \left(\|\vec{\hat{q}} - \vec{q}\|_2 \geq \frac{1}{\sqrt{n}} + \varepsilon \right) \leq e^{-n\varepsilon^2}.$$



Theorem [Estimation of Transition Function]: Suppose we have access to an oracle model of the transition function through which we collect N sample transitions to form the estimate



$$\hat{P}(s' | s, a) = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^N \mathbb{1}[s_i = s, a_i = a, s'_i = s']}{\sum_{i=1}^N \mathbb{1}[s_i = s, a_i = a]}$$

Then, with probability at least $1 - \delta$ for any $\delta > 0$, the following holds:

$$\max_{\substack{s \in S \\ a \in A}} \|\hat{P}(\cdot | s, a) - P(\cdot | s, a)\|_1 \leq \sqrt{\frac{|S|^2 |A| \log\left(\frac{2|S||A|}{\delta}\right)}{N}}$$

Proof (sketch): The proof relies on the following arguments:

- for a single (s, a) pair $\leftarrow$ • Lemma about estimation of categorical distribution
- $\|\cdot\|_2 \rightarrow \|\cdot\|_1 \leftarrow$ • Equivalence of norms $\|E\|_2 \leq \|E\|_1 \leq \sqrt{d} \|E\|_2$ for $E \in \mathbb{R}^d$
- for all (s, a) pairs $\leftarrow$ • Union bound $\mathbb{P}[B_1 \cup B_2 \cup B_3 \cup \dots \cup B_p] \leq \sum_{j=1}^p \mathbb{P}[B_j]$
 $\leq \frac{\epsilon}{|S||A|} \Rightarrow \mathbb{P}\left[\bigcup_{j=1}^p B_j\right] \leq \epsilon$

Question: How does the suboptimality of the learned policy depend on the quality of estimating the transition function?

Occupancy Measures:

$$\sum_{s \in S} \rho_{s_0}^{\pi}(s) = \frac{1}{1-\gamma}$$



state occupancy measure $\rho_{s_0}^{\pi}(s) = \sum_{t=0}^{\infty} \gamma^t P(S_t = s | s_0, \pi, P)$

normalized state occupancy measure $\bar{\rho}_{s_0}^{\pi}(s) = (1-\gamma) \rho_{s_0}^{\pi}(s)$

$$\sum_{s \in S} \bar{\rho}_{s_0}^{\pi}(s) = 1$$

state-action occupancy measure $\gamma_{s_0}^{\pi}(s, a) = \sum_{t=0}^{\infty} \gamma^t P(S_t = s, A_t = a | s_0, \pi, P)$

normalized state-action occupancy measure $\bar{\gamma}_{s_0}^{\pi}(s, a) = (1-\gamma) \gamma_{s_0}^{\pi}(s, a)$

Simulation Lemma: Consider a deterministic policy $\pi: S \rightarrow A$ and two transition functions P and $\hat{P}$ over an infinite-horizon discounted MDP. The value function of policy π under P and $\hat{P}$ satisfies the following:

$$|\hat{V}_{(s_0)}^{\pi} - V_{(s_0)}^{\pi}| \leq \frac{\gamma R_{\max}}{(1-\gamma)^2} \mathbb{E}_{s \sim \bar{\rho}_{s_0}^{\pi}} \left[\underbrace{\|\hat{P}(\cdot | s, \pi(s)) - P(\cdot | s, \pi(s))\|_1}_{\text{capturing TVD}} \right],$$

where $R_{\max} = \max_{s, a} |R(s, a)|$. capturing TVD ($\hat{P}(\cdot | s, \pi(s)), P(\cdot | s, \pi(s))$)
total variation distance

Intuitively:

- Not frequently visited states do not matter
- Actions not taken by the policy do not matter
- If $\hat{P} \approx P \rightarrow \hat{V} \approx V$

Proof: Consider $\hat{v}^\pi$ and v^π as vector representation of the value function of π under $\hat{P}$ and P , respectively.

$$\hat{v}^\pi - v^\pi \xrightarrow{\text{Bellman consistency equation}} = R^\pi + \gamma \hat{P}^\pi \hat{v}^\pi - R^\pi - \gamma P^\pi v^\pi$$

$$\xrightarrow[\text{terms}]{\text{rearrange}} = \gamma (\hat{P}^\pi \hat{v}^\pi - P^\pi v^\pi)$$

$$\xrightarrow[\text{subtract}]{\text{add and}} = \gamma (\hat{P}^\pi \hat{v}^\pi - P^\pi \hat{v}^\pi + P^\pi \hat{v}^\pi - P^\pi v^\pi)$$

$$\xrightarrow[\text{terms}]{\text{rearrange}} = \gamma (\hat{P}^\pi - P^\pi) \hat{v}^\pi + \gamma P^\pi (\hat{v}^\pi - v^\pi)$$

$$\xrightarrow[\text{expand } \hat{v}^\pi - v^\pi]{\text{expand}} = \gamma (\hat{P}^\pi - P^\pi) \hat{v}^\pi + \gamma P^\pi (\gamma (\hat{P}^\pi - P^\pi) \hat{v}^\pi + \gamma P^\pi (\hat{v}^\pi - v^\pi))$$

$$\xrightarrow[\text{terms}]{\text{rearrange}} = \gamma (\hat{P}^\pi - P^\pi) \hat{v}^\pi + \gamma^2 P^\pi (\hat{P}^\pi - P^\pi) \hat{v}^\pi + \gamma^2 (P^\pi)^2 (\hat{v}^\pi - v^\pi)$$

$\vdots$

$$\xrightarrow[\text{iterations}]{\text{after } K} = \sum_{i=1}^K (\gamma^i (P^\pi)^{i-1} (\hat{P}^\pi - P^\pi) \hat{v}^\pi) + \underbrace{\gamma^K (P^\pi)^K (\hat{v}^\pi - v^\pi)}_{\text{goes to zero as } K \rightarrow \infty}$$

$\vdots$

$$\xrightarrow{K \rightarrow \infty} = \sum_{i=1}^{\infty} (\gamma^i (P^\pi)^{i-1} (\hat{P}^\pi - P^\pi) \hat{v}^\pi)$$

Therefore, we have that

$$\hat{v}^\pi - v^\pi = \gamma \sum_{i=0}^{\infty} \gamma^i (P^\pi)^i (\hat{P}^\pi - P^\pi) \hat{v}^\pi.$$

Now, we compare the value function at the initial state.

$$\hat{v}^\pi(s_0) - v^\pi(s_0) = (\hat{v}^\pi - v^\pi)^T e_{s_0} \xrightarrow{\text{standard basis vector}} \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ \vdots \\ 0 \\ 1 \\ 0 \\ \vdots \\ 0 \end{bmatrix} \xrightarrow{s_0^{\text{th}} \text{ entry}} |S| \times 1$$

$$\xrightarrow[\text{based on above}]{\text{based on above}} = \left(\gamma \sum_{i=0}^{\infty} \gamma^i (P^\pi)^i (\hat{P}^\pi - P^\pi) \hat{v}^\pi \right)^T e_{s_0}$$

$$\text{rearrange terms} \leftarrow = \gamma \left((\hat{P}^n - P^n) \hat{V}^n \right)^T \sum_{i=0}^{\infty} \gamma^i (P^n)^i)^T e_{s_0}$$

$$\text{definition of } \bar{P}_{s_0}^n \leftarrow = \frac{\gamma}{1-\gamma} \left((\hat{P}^n - P^n) \hat{V}^n \right)^T \bar{P}_{s_0}^n$$

$$\text{definition of inner product} \leftarrow = \frac{\gamma}{1-\gamma} \sum_{s \in \mathcal{S}} \left((\hat{P}^n - P^n) \hat{V}^n \right)_s \bar{P}_{s_0}^n(s) \quad \text{--- } s^{\text{th}} \text{ entry}$$

$$\text{definition of expectation} \leftarrow = \frac{\gamma}{1-\gamma} \mathbb{E}_{s \sim \bar{P}_{s_0}^n} \left[\left((\hat{P}^n - P^n) \hat{V}^n \right)_s \right]$$

$$\text{definition of matrix multiplication} \leftarrow = \frac{\gamma}{1-\gamma} \mathbb{E}_{s \sim \bar{P}_{s_0}^n} \left[\left(\hat{P}^n - P^n \right)_s \hat{V}^n \right] \quad \text{--- } s^{\text{th}} \text{ row}$$

$$\text{definition of inner product} \leftarrow = \frac{\gamma}{1-\gamma} \mathbb{E}_{s \sim \bar{P}_{s_0}^n} \left[\sum_{s' \in \mathcal{S}} \left(\hat{P}^n(s' | s, \pi(s)) - P^n(s' | s, \pi(s)) \right) \hat{V}^n(s') \right]$$

Taking absolute value, we have

$$\left| \hat{V}^n(s_0) - V^n(s_0) \right| = \left| \frac{\gamma}{1-\gamma} \mathbb{E}_{s \sim \bar{P}_{s_0}^n} \left[\sum_{s' \in \mathcal{S}} \left(\hat{P}^n(s' | s, \pi(s)) - P^n(s' | s, \pi(s)) \right) \hat{V}^n(s') \right] \right|$$

$$\text{triangle inequality} \leftarrow \leq \frac{\gamma}{1-\gamma} \mathbb{E}_{s \sim \bar{P}_{s_0}^n} \left[\sum_{s' \in \mathcal{S}} \left| \hat{P}^n(s' | s, \pi(s)) - P^n(s' | s, \pi(s)) \right| \left| \hat{V}^n(s') \right| \right]$$

$$\text{bound on value function} \leftarrow \leq \frac{\gamma}{1-\gamma} \mathbb{E}_{s \sim \bar{P}_{s_0}^n} \left[\sum_{s' \in \mathcal{S}} \left| \hat{P}^n(s' | s, \pi(s)) - P^n(s' | s, \pi(s)) \right| \frac{R_{\max}}{1-\gamma} \right]$$

$$\text{definition of } L_1 \text{ norm} \leftarrow = \frac{\gamma R_{\max}}{(1-\gamma)^2} \mathbb{E}_{s \sim \bar{P}_{s_0}^n} \left[\left\| \hat{P}(\cdot | s, \pi(s)) - P(\cdot | s, \pi(s)) \right\|_1 \right] \cdot$$

Corollary: In the setting considered in the simulation lemma, it holds that

$$\left| \hat{V}^n(s_0) - V^n(s_0) \right| \leq \frac{\gamma R_{\max}}{(1-\gamma)^2} \underbrace{\max_{\substack{s \in \mathcal{S} \\ a \in \mathcal{A}}} \left\| \hat{P}(\cdot | s, a) - P(\cdot | s, a) \right\|_1}_{\text{no dependence on policy}} \cdot$$

Sub-optimality due to model inaccuracy:

The error in estimating the model, the transition function P and reward function R , leads to sub-optimality of the policy learned from them.

Note:

- Assume that R is known and $\hat{P}$ is an estimate of P .
- Let $\hat{v}^\pi$ be the value function of a policy π evaluated using $\hat{P}$.
- Let $\hat{\pi}^*$ be the policy learned using $\hat{P}$ as an optimal policy.

The sub-optimality of $\hat{\pi}^*$ is:

$$\begin{aligned} 0 &\leq V^*(s_0) - V^{\hat{\pi}^*}(s_0) \stackrel{\text{for a } \pi^*}{=} V^{\pi^*}(s_0) - V^{\hat{\pi}^*}(s_0) \\ &\stackrel{\text{add \& subtract term}}{=} V^{\pi^*}(s_0) - \hat{V}^{\hat{\pi}^*}(s_0) + \hat{V}^{\hat{\pi}^*}(s_0) - V^{\hat{\pi}^*}(s_0) \\ &\stackrel{\hat{V}^{\pi^*} \leq \hat{V}^{\hat{\pi}^*}}{\leq} \underbrace{V^{\pi^*}(s_0) - \hat{V}^{\pi^*}(s_0)}_{\substack{\pi^* \text{ evaluated} \\ \text{over two models}}} + \underbrace{\hat{V}^{\hat{\pi}^*}(s_0) - V^{\hat{\pi}^*}(s_0)}_{\substack{\hat{\pi}^* \text{ evaluated} \\ \text{over two models}}} \end{aligned}$$

→

$$\begin{aligned} |V^*(s_0) - V^{\hat{\pi}^*}(s_0)| &\leq |V^{\pi^*}(s_0) - \hat{V}^{\pi^*}(s_0) + \hat{V}^{\hat{\pi}^*}(s_0) - V^{\hat{\pi}^*}(s_0)| \\ &\leq |V^{\pi^*}(s_0) - \hat{V}^{\pi^*}(s_0)| + |\hat{V}^{\hat{\pi}^*}(s_0) - V^{\hat{\pi}^*}(s_0)| \end{aligned}$$

$$\stackrel{\substack{\text{applying the corollary} \\ \text{from the simulation lemma}}}{\leq} \frac{2\gamma R_{\max}}{(1-\gamma)^2} \max_{\substack{s \in \mathcal{S} \\ a \in \mathcal{A}}} \|\hat{P}(\cdot|s,a) - P(\cdot|s,a)\|_1$$

Theorem [sub-optimality of policy]: In the setting with oracle access to the model, for any $\delta > 0$ and $\epsilon > 0$, the model-based RL algorithm with N samples

$$N \geq \frac{4\gamma^2 R_{\max}^2 |S|^2 |A| \log\left(\frac{2|S||A|}{\delta}\right)}{\epsilon^2 (1-\gamma)^4}$$

will result in $\hat{\pi}^*$ such that with probability at least $1 - \delta$,

$$V_{(s)}^* - V_{(s)}^{\hat{\pi}^*} \leq \epsilon \quad \forall s \in S.$$